

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: AFP

SoftBank, a Japanese tech and telecoms giant, will build data centres for **artificial intelligence** in Hauts-de-France, a region in northern France. The firm will build three centres by 2031 at a cost of €45bn (\$53bn). It eventually plans to spend up to €75bn, creating Europe's largest data-centre network. [SoftBank](#) has invested heavily in AI, including almost \$65bn in OpenAI, the maker of ChatGPT.

Chinese manufacturing remained steady in May, as weak domestic demand and the increased cost of inputs caused by the Iran war took their toll. The purchasing managers' index, a survey of business activity, fell from 50.3 in April to 50—on the line between contraction and expansion. China's non-manufacturing PMI rose from 49.4 to 50.1.

Pete Hegseth told an audience at the **Shangri-La Dialogue**, an annual gabfest of defence ministers, that America's relations with China were "better than they've been in many years". But America's secretary of war said that China's "historic military build-up" meant that his country's allies ought to spend more on defence. Last year Mr Hegseth warned of the "threat" of China invading Taiwan; this year he [did not mention the island](#).

A flurry of **defence tie-ups** were also announced at **Shangri-La**. America, Australia and Britain (an alliance known as AUKUS) said they would together develop aquatic drones to protect subsea cables. Mr Hegseth declared that America, Japan and South Korea were “deepening” their defence co-operation. And India said that it had finalised with Vietnam a sale of its supersonic, long-range BrahMos missiles.

Colombia accused **Ecuador** of interfering in its [upcoming election](#), after Ecuador’s president promised to lift tariffs on Colombian imports. The pledge was part of an agreement made with Abelardo de la Espriella, an opposition candidate. Colombia said Ecuador’s decision to remove the tariffs was not a “goodwill gesture”. But it also agreed to repeal reciprocal measures it had placed on its neighbour, thawing a months-long trade war.

Russia recalled its ambassador to **Armenia** in protest at its ally’s attempts to establish closer ties with the European Union. Its foreign ministry accused Armenia of “undermining” the Russia-led Eurasian Economic Union. It had earlier threatened to halt or end the supply of oil, gas and diamonds to Armenia after the country declared it wanted to join the EU.

Paris St Germain defeated Arsenal in a penalty shoot-out to win its second consecutive **Champions League** final. Fresh off their [English Premier League win](#), the North-London side hoped to take down PSG. They fought the French powerhouse to a 1-1 draw, but two poor penalties sent the trophy back to Paris.

Word of the week: *Hivernauts*, those who spend the winter in the extreme isolation of a polar research station in Antarctica. Read about the impact [such an environment](#) can have.



Photograph: AP

Polar opposites at Colombia's polls

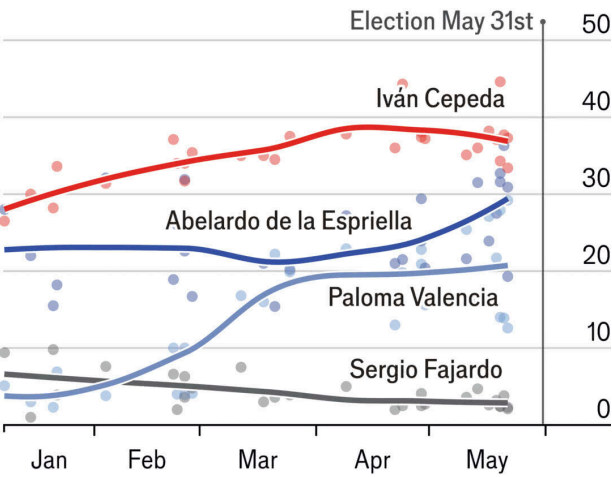
The [stakes are unusually high](#) in the first round of Colombia's presidential election on Sunday. The main candidates have radically different ideas on handling one of the world's most unequal economies, and on stopping violence and drug-trafficking in the country that supplies two-thirds of all cocaine.

Iván Cepeda, an austere leftist ally of the current president, wants to continue “total peace”, a policy of negotiating with all criminal groups simultaneously. Yet violence and cocaine production have risen rather than fallen under the approach. Business leaders, meanwhile, fear Mr Cepeda's penchant for higher taxes and redistribution.

The other main contenders are Abelardo de la Espriella, a hard-right Trumpian who calls himself “El Tigre” (the tiger), and Paloma Valencia, a centre-right senator. El Tigre—who models himself partly on Nayib Bukele, El Salvador's dictator, and sports a near identical beard—promises to build ten mega-prisons in the jungle. He is now the favourite to make it through to a run-off with Mr Cepeda. If so, Colombians face a stark choice.

Starters' orders

Colombia, voting intention in first round
of presidential election, 2026, %
Main candidates



Source: La Silla Vacía



Photograph: EPA

Fire by trial for the Turkish opposition

The Republican People's Party (CHP), Turkey's main opposition, reeled last week after a court in Ankara [deposed its leader](#), Ozgur Ozel, and replaced him with its previous chairman, Kemal Kilicdaroglu. Mr Ozel pledged to reclaim his post; Mr Kilicdaroglu vowed to stay on until the next party convention. The two men are holding competing rallies over the weekend.

The CHP base has gathered behind Mr Ozel, who helped his party beat Recep Tayyip Erdogan, Turkey's president, and his ruling Justice and Development party in local elections in 2024. Most analysts are certain that Mr Ozel's ousting is the latest instalment in Mr Erdogan's ongoing crackdown on Turkey's oldest party. More than 20 of the party's mayors—including Ekrem Imamoglu, the mayor of Istanbul and the CHP's presidential candidate—have been arrested on dubious corruption charges since the elections. Struggling to beat the opposition at the ballot box, Mr Erdogan seems determined to dismantle it through the courts.



Photograph: Getty Images

Israel's fractious election

On May 20th the Knesset, Israel's parliament, voted preliminarily to dissolve itself. Binyamin Netanyahu, the prime minister, has been trying to stall a final vote, after which parliament must set a date for elections. Mr Netanyahu's coalition of nationalist and religious parties lacks a majority in polls. On Monday the Knesset is expected to finally dissolve itself and set a date. Campaigning is already in full swing.

Mr Netanyahu, Israel's longest-serving prime minister, has a [chance of remaining in power](#) because the opposition is fractured. One challenger is Naftali Bennett, a former prime minister who has the support of Yair Lapid, the leader of the opposition. If elected, Mr Bennett has promised to quickly launch an inquiry into failures that led to the massacre on October 7th 2023. Gadi Eisenkot, a former general, has also been rising in polls. Both candidates may benefit from the unresolved anger of voters at Mr Netanyahu for not stopping the bloodiest attack in Israel's history.



Photograph: Reuters

A record-breaking IPL ends

Twenty20, cricket's shortest format, prizes power over patience. This year's Indian Premier League, the world's leading T20 competition, has taken that to an extreme. Batsmen have dominated bowlers, with teams scoring at an average rate of nearly ten runs an over, up from below nine in 2023. Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, [a 15-year-old prodigy](#) with the Rajasthan Royals, has led the charge, amassing 776 runs. He may yet be overtaken. On Sunday Shubman Gill, captain of Gujarat Titans, who has 722 runs, faces Royal Challengers Bengaluru, the defending champions, in the final.

The run feast has unsettled some fans, who grumble that flat pitches and rule tweaks have upset the balance of the game. But these purists are a minority, and tend to prefer Test cricket (a longer form) anyway. Broadcasters say this season's IPL has reached a record 1.1bn viewers across television and digital platforms. Even critics may be bowled over by such a number.



Photograph: Jennifer Buhl

The hidden tastemakers of the literary world

Literary agents have many functions. They are scouts, identifying promising writers. They are confidants, helping writers to produce their best work. And then they are negotiators, doing deals on their behalf. So argues Laura McGrath (pictured) in “Middlemen”, a lively behind-the-scenes account of how books reach shelves, which is out in America and will come out in June in Britain.

The invisible go-betweeners of the publishing world have long been controversial figures. They are never objective, and their preferences shape what is printed. Some are particularly enterprising: for instance, Andrew Wylie (known as “the Jackal”), who handled both Philip Roth’s and Henry Kissinger’s literary affairs, and changed the “shape of American literature abroad”. But mediocre ones leave their mark, too. There has been a proliferation in agents; there has also been a multiplication of uninspiring books. When tastes and trends are increasingly shaped by algorithms, it is striking how much an agent’s judgment still matters.

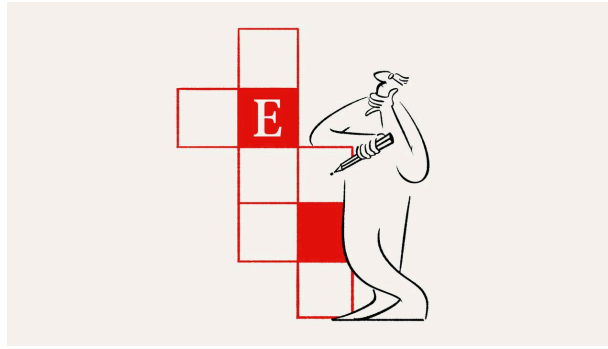


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Some fool gives back to house a homeless eskimo (5)

2 across - Bum around November goes down in history (5)

3 across - Unacceptable, whichever way you look at it (3,2)

1 down - Supply in loaf tin gets more expensive (9)

Straight clues

1 across - An icy dwelling (5)

2 across - A historical record (5)

3 across - Unthinkable; off or postponed (3,2)

1 down - Growth, not always welcome (5)

*Guilt is born in the same hour
with pleasure, like anything in this
universe and its enemy.*

Ama Ata Aidoo